

What have we learned from 13,676 offenders and 97 correctional programs? *Crime and Delinquency*, 52, 77–93.

Boot Camps

Intermediate sanctions are a vital component of the criminal and juvenile justice systems, in which offenders have alternative options of rehabilitation. Rather than being incarcerated or placed on probation, the justice system has the ability to use an intermediate sanction to rehabilitate an offender. Boot camps represent a type of intermediate sanction. Boot camps, also referred to as shock or intensive incarceration programs, are short-term, in-prison programs that largely resemble military basic training. These programs are heavily structured and emphasize rigorous physical activity and manual labor. They were originally designed to reduce prison populations and associated operating costs as well as reduce recidivism rates through modifying offenders' negative behaviors.

Although some speculate that correctional boot camps have been around in the United States since the early 1970s, the first recognized programs were not established until 1983 in Georgia and Oklahoma. Following their initial implementation, boot camps proliferated across the country throughout the late 1980s and early 1990s. By 1995, there were 75 state-facilitated boot camps for adults. The use of boot camps was not isolated to adult offenders, however. In 1985, the first juvenile boot camp was established in Louisiana. During the 1990s, partially in response to the tough-on-crime ideology, juvenile boot camps became a popular sentencing option. In 1996, there were 48 established juvenile boot camps in 27 different states. The fascination with boot camps began to wane during the latter part of the 1990s, with nearly one-third of state-run prison boot camps being shut down by 2000. As of 2009, only 11 states operated boot camps for juvenile offenders. Though the number of camps have dwindled in recent decades, boot camps continue to be an alternative to long-term incarceration for both juvenile and adult offenders in some states.

Boot camps are not utilized or well suited for all types of offenders. The majority of adult boot camps reserve participation for young, first-time, nonviolent offenders. For juvenile boot camps, eligible offenders are typically in their mid-to-late teens who have prior experience with the juvenile justice system and have failed to be successful with less severe sanctions, but who are not serious enough offenders to be eligible for placement in a state facility. For both juvenile and adult boot camps, participation is largely restricted to male offenders, though there are some female boot camps in existence.

Boot camps are designed to resemble military basic training. Therefore, there is a large emphasis on structure, physical training, manual labor, drill and ceremony, and summary punishment (i.e., immediate sanction for an infraction such as extra chores, pushups, etc.). Many programs also have rehabilitative and treatment components, though the types of activities included as part of these components vary greatly from program to program. Many boot camps with treatment components include academic and vocational education, drug and alcohol treatment, different types of therapy, and life skills training. In juvenile boot camps, this emphasis on rehabilitation is particularly salient. According to a study conducted jointly by the Institute for Criminological Research and the National Institute of Justice, juvenile boot camps spend more than half of each day on education and counseling activities. Additionally, most juvenile boot camp programs include substance abuse treatment, rehabilitative counseling, and intensive community supervision upon release.

Boot camps were designed to achieve three main goals. The main goal is to reduce recidivism among offenders by modifying their behavior through positive reinforcement of appropriate behavior and immediate punishment of negative behavior. Another goal is to reduce the number of incarcerated offenders by diverting them from traditional incarceration facilities to boot camps. A final goal, which is partially dependent on the first two goals, is the reduction of correctional operating costs. If boot camps are able to reduce the number of incarcerated offenders as well as rehabilitate boot camp participants, then theoretically, correctional operating costs should be reduced.

Evaluations have been conducted to assess whether adult and juvenile boot camps are successful in achieving these goals. Studies have consistently found that boot camps do not significantly reduce recidivism rates. This finding holds true for both juvenile and adult boot camps. Additionally, it has been found that the emphasis of the program, whether heavily militarized or more focused on treatment, does not have an impact on recidivism. Both types of programs fail to significantly reduce recidivism rates. Researchers have identified a number of limitations to explain the failure to reduce recidivism including low "dosage" effects and insufficient preparation of participants for reentry. Some researchers argue that recidivism is not impacted because the length of stay is too short to have any realistic effect. Essentially, they argue that real and long-lasting changes in behavior cannot be

achieved in the 90 to 120 days that is typical of most boot camp programs. Other researchers argue that recidivism is not impacted because boot camps do not prepare graduates for life after release. Many programs provide little to no postrelease programming to prepare graduates to be successful once released. However, many programs require intensive supervision upon release. The lack of adequate preparation coupled with intensive surveillance increases the likelihood that graduates will violate probation or reoffend.

Mixed results have been found regarding whether boot camps reduce prison populations. An NIJ multisite study on adult boot camps in Louisiana and New York found that the programs did reduce the need for prison beds in these states. A study exploring juvenile boot camps in South Dakota and Oregon found similar findings. However, the restrictive criteria for boot camp participants, particularly for adult boot camps, impact the ability to significantly reduce prison populations. Due to the failure of boot camps to either reduce recidivism or have a significant impact on prison populations, the goal of reducing operating costs is also usually not achieved. Despite the shortcomings of most boot camp programs, they continue to be used in many states across the country. Many of the boot camps that remain in existence today have reviewed the findings from previous evaluations and are making changes to their programs in order to attempt to increase their effectiveness.

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See also: [Continuum of Sanctions](#); [Correctional Officers with Military Experience](#); [Cost of Prisons](#); [Evidence-Based Practice in Corrections](#); [Inmates' Perceptions of Prison versus Alternative Sanctions](#); [Prison Populations, Downsizing of](#); [Recidivism](#)

Further Reading

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Building Tenders

The term “building tenders” refers to the historical use of inmates as a correctional management tool. Although building tenders is often used interchangeably with the related term “inmate trusty,” the two terms have come to have different connotations over time. In a contemporary sense, prison or jail trustees are commonly characterized as lower risk inmates who are allotted additional privileges in exchange for the labor that they provide to correctional institutions. Building tenders, on the other hand, refers to a group of inmates who were historically granted substantive power and authority over other inmates by prison administrators in exchange for their ability to maintain order within correctional institutions and ensure inmate compliance with institutional directives. The use of building tenders in the American prison system was most prominent during the 1960s and 1970s and was at least partially driven by increasing prison populations, which challenged the ability of prison officials to maintain institutional order. Although the use of building tenders in the United States is most strongly linked to the Texas prison system, building tenders were also commonly employed by prison systems in Arkansas, Louisiana, Alabama, and Mississippi.

Building tenders were frequently selected precisely because they were intimidating inmates who were willing and able to use violence to accomplish their assigned duties within the institutions that incarcerated them. This willingness to use force in the form of extortion, threats, and beatings ultimately contributed to tenders having fearsome institutional reputations. Due to their willingness to harm other inmates, the special privileges that they enjoyed as a result of this propensity, and the symbiotic relationships that they cultivated with institutional staff, building tenders were both feared and despised by the rest of the inmate population. In order to accomplish their

duties, building tenders were allowed to enlist the help of other inmates, were given access to otherwise off limits areas of the institutions that housed them, and often had access to crude weapons. The continuation